GASTON

BASIC HUMAN TASTES

Master sequencer: eight trigger tracks, four CV tracks, one clock

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Gaston is the master sequencer of the patch, designed to drive Ernest drum voices. It has eight trigger tracks with a probability on every step, four CV tracks for pitches and modulation, a built-in clock with swing, and a transport that works like a DJ's CDJ player: CUE and PLAY/PAUSE.

Every track has its own length, clock ratio and direction, so polyrhythms and polymeters come from a few simple settings. You edit one track at a time on a ribbon of 16 steps. Below it, the map shows all twelve tracks as they play, and a square flashes white only when a trigger actually leaves.

AT A GLANCE

- 8 trigger tracks with per-step probability, 4 CV tracks with per-step voltage
- Each track: its own LENGTH (1 to 64 steps), RATIO (12, from ÷4 to x4) and direction
- Built-in clock, 30 to 300 BPM, swing, optional vintage 96 PPQN timing, or an external clock
- CDJ-style CUE and PLAY/PAUSE, eight pads with live recording, mutes
- A map of all twelve tracks with progress rails
- Pattern memories and song mode with the Gastounet expander
- 36 HP

CONTROLS

Clock screen	The tempo, to a tenth of a BPM. With CLOCK IN patched it shows the measured tempo, and EXT instead of BPM. The swing value sits above the SWING knob; with vintage timing on, it shows the rounded value under a small 96.
TEMPO	Internal clock, from 30 to 300 BPM in quarter notes (default 120). Gaston counts in sixteenths: four master steps per beat. Ignored while CLOCK IN is patched.
SWING	From 50 % (straight, default) to 75 %. Delays the second sixteenth of each pair: at 66 % it lands two thirds of the way through the pair. Only the binary ratios swing (see the ratio table), and CLOCK OUT swings with them.
REC	Arms pad recording; the red light shows it. While the transport plays, each pad hit is also written into its track. The pads turn red-orange and the screen reads TRIGS · REC.
CUE	Stopped: hold it to play from the start, release it to go back to the start and stop. Playing: back to the start and stop. Hold CUE and press PLAY/PAUSE to keep playing when you let go. Lit while held.
PLAY / PAUSE	Starts or pauses. A pause keeps the position and the next press resumes from there. Lit while playing. Gaston always loads paused, at the start.
Track screen	The selected track (TRACK 1 to 8, or CV A to D) and its kind: TRIGS, or the CV range with FREE or SEMITONES. Then its LENGTH, RATIO, DIR, the STEP being played, and the PAGE shown out of the pages the track uses (2/3).
LENGTH	Number of steps the selected track plays, 1 to 64 (default 16). Steps past it are kept, just not played.
RATIO	Speed of the selected track against the master step: twelve positions from ÷4 to x4 (default x1). See the ratio table.
DIR	Each press moves the selected track to the next direction: FWD, REV, PING-PONG, RANDOM. The arrow on the button (a question mark for RANDOM) and the readout show it. PING-PONG does not repeat the end steps; RANDOM picks any step within LENGTH each time.
SLEW	CV tracks only. Glide between steps, 0 to 100 %. At 0, instant jumps. Above, an exponential glide whose time constant goes from 2 ms to 1 s (about 45 ms at 50 %).
±5 V · 0-10 V	CV tracks only. Output range of the selected track (default ±5 V). The bars keep their place when you switch: their voltages are rescaled.
FREE · SEMI	CV tracks only. FREE (default): any voltage. SEMI: each step rounds to the nearest semitone (1/12 V) and the readouts show notes, 0 V = C4.
PAGE	Four buttons for the four pages of 16 steps (1–16, 17–32, 33–48, 49–64). You turn pages by hand: Gaston never does it for you. Pages past LENGTH are dimmed but can still be opened and edited. When the selected track is playing on another page, a dot blinks on that page's button.
SELECT	Twelve buttons: round 1 to 8 for the trigger tracks, square A to D for the CV tracks. Picks the track shown on the screen and the ribbon; LENGTH, RATIO and SLEW jump to its values. On a CV track the whole step block turns verdigris. A muted track's number is dimmed.
PADS	One pad per trigger track. A hit always sends a trigger to the track's output, even when the track is muted. With REC armed and the transport playing, it also writes the hit into the track.
MUTE	One switch per trigger track, lit when muted. Immediate: the track keeps moving but its steps send nothing.
Lights	Above each SELECT button. Trigger tracks: a flash on every trigger that leaves, from the sequence or a pad. CV tracks: a flash on every active step.

CV readouts	Under the CV select buttons: a small meter and the voltage each CV output is sending right now, after SLEW, or the note when the track is set to SEMI.

RATIOS

RATIO	One step lasts	At 120 BPM	Swing
÷4	A quarter note (4 master steps)	500 ms	Binary, but every step falls on an unswung sixteenth
÷3	A dotted eighth (3 master steps)	375 ms	Straight
÷2	An eighth note (2 master steps)	250 ms	Binary, but every step falls on an unswung sixteenth
x2/3	A dotted sixteenth (2 steps for 3 master steps)	188 ms	Straight
x3/4	An eighth-note triplet (3 per beat)	167 ms	Straight
x1	A sixteenth, the master step (default)	125 ms	Swings
x5/4	A quintuplet sixteenth (5 per beat)	100 ms	Straight
x4/3	A dotted thirty-second (4 steps for 3 master steps)	94 ms	Straight
x3/2	A sixteenth-note triplet (6 per beat)	83 ms	Straight
x2	A thirty-second note	63 ms	Swings
x3	A thirty-second triplet (12 per beat)	42 ms	Straight
x4	A sixty-fourth note	31 ms	Swings

EDIT RIBBON AND MAP

Step numbers	Above the ribbon, the numbers of the 16 steps of the page shown (17 to 32 on page 2, and so on), in groups of four. The number of the step being played lights up.
Trigger step	Click the square to turn a step on or off. A step turned on starts at 100 %. The step being played glows, and flashes when it fires. Steps past LENGTH are dimmed but stay editable.
Probability	The thin gauge under each lit step: its chance of firing, from 1 to 100 %. Drag it up or down: 1 % per pixel of mouse travel, whatever the zoom. No number, no snapping. Double-click it to go back to 100 %. Empty and dotted on a step that is off.
CV bar	On a CV track each step is a bar, drawn from a centre line in ±5 V or from the bottom in 0–10 V. Click in the bar area to set the voltage at that height, then drag to adjust it: 1 V per 24 pixels of mouse travel (a semitone every 2 pixels), whatever the zoom. Double-click a bar to bring it back to the centre value.
CV readout	The strip at the bottom of each CV step shows its value: +2.3 in ±5 V, 7.5 in 0–10 V, or a note such as Eb4 in SEMI. Clicking it does not change the value; dragging from it adjusts the value without a jump. Dimmed on an inactive step.
Activation row	The thin row under each CV step. Solid: the step sets its voltage (default). Dotted: the step is inactive and the output keeps the voltage of the last active step (sample and hold). Click to switch.
Fine adjustment	Hold Ctrl (Cmd on Mac) while dragging a bar or a probability gauge to move 16 times more slowly, as with Rack's knobs. Ctrl-clicking a bar does not make it jump to the mouse.
Alt-click	Alt-click (Option-click on Mac) on any step, on any page, makes it the last one: LENGTH jumps to that step.

MAP	All twelve tracks, one row each (1 to 8, then A to D), on the page shown and in line with the ribbon. Trigger rows: steps that are on are lit, paler as their probability drops. CV rows: active steps are lit, brighter the further they are from the centre. Steps past LENGTH are not drawn. Click a row to select its track.
Progress rail	A thin rail behind each row runs from the start of the cycle to the step being played, with a bright edge, and drops back when the track loops. In REV it runs from the right, in PING-PONG it follows the direction, in RANDOM there is none.
White flash	A map square turns white only when a trigger really leaves: the probability draw passed and the track is not muted. Pad hits and CV tracks do not flash on the map.

RIGHT-CLICK MENUS

Step value	Right-click on a step: the top of the menu holds a field to type its value, applied with Enter. CV track: volts, or on a SEMI track a note such as Eb4 (C4 = 0 V) or volts. Trigger track: the probability in %, which also turns the step on. Below the field, Reset step does what a double-click does.
Ribbon menu	Right-click on the ribbon for the menu of the selected track, below the step value when you click on a step. Its title names the track.
Clear track	Trigger track: all steps off, back to 100 %. CV track: all steps at the centre value and active. LENGTH, RATIO and DIR are kept.
Randomize	Over all 64 steps. Trigger track: about 30 % of the steps on, at 100 %. CV track: a random voltage on every step, all active.
Shift one step	Left or right: rotates the steps within LENGTH, the last one wrapping round to the first, probabilities and voltages included.
Copy · paste track	Steps and settings (LENGTH, RATIO, DIR and, for CV tracks, range, quantize and SLEW). Pastes only onto a track of the same kind, and works between all the Gastons of the patch.
Copy · paste page	The 16 steps of the page shown, to paste onto another page or another track of the same kind.
Module menu	Right-click on the panel. The Clock section holds the four settings below, saved with the patch.
CLOCK IN resolution	Pulses per master step expected at CLOCK IN: 1 per step (4 PPQN, default), 2 per step (8 PPQN), 24 PPQN or 48 PPQN.
CLOCK OUT resolution	The same four choices for CLOCK OUT.
Vintage timing	Vintage timing (96 PPQN), off by default. See How it works.
Realign all tracks	Never (default), every 16, 32 or 64 master steps (1, 2 or 4 bars): all tracks go back to step 1 together, so polymeters meet again.

INPUTS

CLOCK	External clock, replacing TEMPO; the resolution is set in the menu. Gaston measures the pulses, shows the tempo with EXT and moves smoothly between them without running past the next one, so faster ratios fall between pulses. Pulses are ignored while paused; after a return to the start, the next pulse plays step 1. SWING still applies.
PLAY	A trigger toggles play and pause, like the PLAY/PAUSE button.
RESET	A trigger sends every track back to step 1 without stopping or starting the transport. RESET OUT fires.
PADS	Polyphonic, up to 8 channels: channel N plays, and records, like pad N.

OUTPUTS

CLOCK	10 V pulses on the swung grid while playing, at the resolution chosen in the menu (one per sixteenth by default). Each pulse lasts 5 ms, or half the interval at fast rates.
RUN	10 V while the transport plays, CUE included.
RESET	A 10 V, 2 ms pulse each time Gaston goes back to the start: CUE, RESET IN, or the end of a song with Gastounet.
OUT 1 to 8	A 10 V, 10 ms trigger for each step that fires, and for each pad hit.
POLY	The eight trigger tracks in one 8-channel cable.
A to D	The four CV tracks, ±5 V or 0–10 V, after SLEW.

HOW IT WORKS

One track at a time

Gaston has twelve tracks but one ribbon. SELECT chooses the track you edit; the ribbon shows 16 of its steps, on the page chosen with PAGE, and LENGTH, RATIO, DIR and SLEW act on it. The map keeps all twelve in view on the same page, so you can watch the others while editing one.

Master steps, ratios and lengths

Everything is counted in master steps, the sixteenths of the clock. A track at x1 moves one step per master step, at x3/2 three steps for every two, at ÷4 one step per beat. All tracks start together on step 1 and keep counting from there, so a 5-step track against a 16-step one, or a x3/4 track against a x1 one, drifts and meets again on its own schedule. Realign all tracks, in the menu, brings them back to step 1 every 1, 2 or 4 bars.

Probability is drawn each time a lit step comes round: a 50 % step plays about every other pass.

Recording from the pads

With REC armed and the transport playing, a pad hit writes a step at 100 % on its track. A hit in the first half of a step goes on that step. A hit in the second half goes on the next step, which then stays silent on that pass, since you have just heard it. Recording only adds steps: nothing is erased. In RANDOM the hit always goes on the current step. There is no step-by-step recording.

CV tracks

Each step holds a voltage and sends it when the track reaches it. An inactive step sends nothing new, so the previous voltage carries on: turn a few steps off to hold notes longer. CV tracks have their own LENGTH, RATIO and DIR, independent from the trigger tracks, which makes it easy to lay a 7-note melody over a 16-step rhythm.

Vintage timing

Turned on in the menu, it rounds every event, swing included, to a 96 PPQN grid (24 ticks per sixteenth) and adds a random delay of 0 to 0.8 ms to each trigger, clock pulse and CV change. It recreates the feel of the classic hardware samplers. Swing then moves in notches of about 2 %.

Gastounet: memories and song

Attach the Gastounet expander to Gaston's left side to store the working pattern in 64 memories (4 banks of 16) and chain them into a song. Gaston then shows PATTERN A03 at the top of its panel (SONG A03 in song mode), followed by EDITED once the pattern differs from its memory. Mutes, tempo and swing are not part of a pattern.

The memories live inside Gaston and are saved with it, so they stay there if Gastounet is removed. Initializing Gaston clears them too. Gastounet has its own manual.

PATCH IDEAS

1. A drum kit

Four Ernests on OUT 1 to 4: kick, snare, hats, tom. Put track 3 at x2 for thirty-second hats, a few of its steps between 40 and 70 %, and SWING around 56 %.

2. Polymeter that comes home

Track 1 at 16 steps, track 2 at 5, track 3 at 7 with RATIO x3/4. Set Realign all tracks to every 64 steps: the parts drift for four bars, then start together again.

3. Bass line

CV A in ±5 V and SEMI into an Ernest's V/OCT, track 1 into its TRIG. Give CV A a LENGTH of 7 against 16 for track 1, turn a few steps inactive to hold notes, and add a little SLEW for glides.

4. Slow modulation

CV B in 0–10 V and FREE, RATIO ÷4, SLEW around 70 %, into Marcel's ERODE input: the loop forgets more on some beats than on others.

5. Finger drumming

Rack's MIDI-Gate module, its first eight gates merged into one cable with Merge, into PADS IN. Arm REC, press PLAY/PAUSE and play from a pad controller: each hit lands on the nearest step.

6. Audition, then launch

While stopped, hold CUE to hear the pattern from the top and release it to go back. Press PLAY/PAUSE while holding CUE to launch it for real.

SPECIFICATIONS

Width	36 HP
Tracks	8 trigger tracks with per-step probability (1 to 100 %), 4 CV tracks; up to 64 steps each, in 4 pages of 16
Clock	30 to 300 BPM, sixteenth-note master step; external clock at 4, 8, 24 or 48 PPQN
Swing	50 to 75 %. Vintage timing: 96 PPQN grid, 0 to 0.8 ms of random delay per event
Ratios	12 per track, from ÷4 to x4
Levels	Triggers 10 V, 10 ms. CV ±5 V or 0–10 V. CLOCK OUT 10 V, up to 5 ms. RUN 10 V gate. RESET OUT 10 V, 2 ms. Inputs react above about 1 V. POLY: 8 channels.